to challenge his authority. He collected around himself a core team of bureaucrats who were fiercely loyal. ‘Modi gives clear orders, and then allows us the freedom to implement them. What more can a bureaucrat ask for?’ one of the IAS officers told me. No file would remain on his table for long. Fastidious about order and cleanliness, he liked a spotless, paper-free table.

Three IAS officers, K. Kailashnathan, A.K. Sharma and G.C. Murmu, formed a well-knit troika—‘Modi’s men’ is how they were perceived. Another bureaucrat, P.K. Mishra, guided him through the early period. All low-profile, loyal and diligent, they were just the kind of people Modi liked around him. ‘They are more powerful than any minister in Modi’s cabinet,’ was the constant refrain in Gandhinagar. It was true—Modi’s cabinet meetings lasted less than half an hour; he would spend a considerably longer time getting presentations from bureaucrats. For an outwardly self-assured individual, Modi seemed strangely paranoid about his political peers. At one stage, he kept fourteen portfolios with him—his ministerial colleagues, naturally, were unhappy.

One of the disgruntled ministers came to see me once in Delhi. ‘Rajdeepji, I am planning to leave the government. Modiji doesn’t trust me, he still thinks I am a Keshubhai man,’ the senior minister said. A few months later, when I met the minister, I asked him why he hadn’t resigned yet. ‘Well, I have realized that in Gujarat, if you want to remain politically relevant, you have no choice but to be with Modi,’ he said.

The minister was right. The ever-pragmatic Gujarati’s business, they say, is business. The brightest minds find their way into *dhanda* (entrepreneurship)—politics hardly attracts any talent. The Congress, in particular, was a party in sharp decline, haunted by the familiar malaise of not empowering its local leadership. Their main leader, Shankersinh Vaghela, had spent most of his career in the BJP. ‘How can we take on the RSS when we have made an RSS man our face in Gujarat?’ Congressmen would often tell me.

Compared to his political competition, Modi was not only razor-sharp but always quick to seize on new ways to motivate his administration and push